

CORRECTED RESEARCH NOTE

Carl Webb and the Somerton Man inscription

A critical assessment of the technical-lettering hypothesis

Document status	Corrected research note - not a forensic authorship report
Date	21 August 2026
Version	2.0
Prepared for	Somerton Man itinerary-hypothesis research repository

Scope

This note revises an unattributed three-page document supplied to the project under the title Paleographic & Motor-Habit Analysis of the Somerton Man Inscription. The original proposed that Carl Webb wrote the inscription, that his instrument-making work explained particular letterforms, and that the letters were mnemonic initials for unpublished poetry.

Those are hypotheses, not established findings. The supplied report contains useful questions, but its factual errors, missing source material and unsupported precision prevent it from being treated as forensic evidence. This revision separates observation from inference, corrects the traceable errors and defines the evidence needed for a proper test.

Executive assessment

The surviving material does not presently support an attribution of the inscription to Carl Webb. Webb's reported occupation as an instrument maker makes technical-lettering training a reasonable lead, but occupation is not handwriting identification. No authenticated Webb handwriting has been compared with the questioned inscription, and the supplied report contains no original inscription image, calibration, measurements or documented examination method.

The proposition that the letters are word initials remains plausible in a broad sense. The evidence does not distinguish unpublished poetry from a personal mnemonic, an itinerary, a cipher, notes copied from another source or meaningless writing. Initial letters cannot, by themselves, establish poetic metre.

Evidence-status summary

Status	Position at 21 August 2026
Documented	A male body was found at Somerton Beach on 1 December 1948. Police received the associated Rubaiyat on 22 July 1949; it contained a letter sequence and telephone number.
Documented about Webb	Records reported by ABC give Carl Webb's birth as 16 November 1905 in Footscray. His 1941 marriage certificate records his occupation as instrument maker.
Strongly reported, not yet a coronial finding	Derek Abbott and Colleen Fitzpatrick announced in 2022 that genetic genealogy identified the man as Webb. In July 2026 SAPOL said its coronial investigation remained ongoing.
Unresolved	Who wrote the inscription; the best transcription of disputed letters and deletion marks; what the sequence represents; and whether it contains meaningful text.
Unsupported by the supplied report	A 0.1 mm glyph match; the writer's stroke order; a terminal S; telegraphic writing habits; Webb's authorship; poetic metre; and unpublished quatrains.

Corrected factual basis

Identity and biographical record

The supplied report gives Webb's birth as 1 May 1905. The birth-certificate information reported by ABC gives 16 November 1905 in Footscray, Victoria. The supplied report also describes the Webb identification as confirmed by the University of Adelaide and Forensic Science South Australia. That is too strong. Abbott and Fitzpatrick announced the result in

2022 On 6 July 2026, SAPOL said its coronial investigation was still under way and its report would be provided to the Coroner when complete.

This note therefore uses Carl Webb as the leading working identification, while keeping the distinction between a research identification and a published coronial finding.

The report's references to National Archives of Australia series A433 and B2455 as Victorian electoral-roll sources are wrong. A433 is restricted-immigration correspondence and B2455 contains First Australian Imperial Force personnel dossiers. The occupation of instrument maker is supported instead by the 1941 marriage certificate described in the ABC biographical account. The broader labels "electrical engineer", "poet" and "lyricist" require their own identified primary records before being used as established biography.

The Rubaiyat and inscription

State Records of South Australia records that police received the book on 22 July 1949. It had reportedly been found in a car around 30 November 1948 and contained a handwritten note thought to be a code and a telephone number. The supplied report's more specific description of a 1941 Whitcombe & Tombs edition, rear flyleaf, graphite indentation, oblique tungsten lighting and ultraviolet-induced fluorescence is not supported by a cited police exhibit or technical report within the document. Those details should remain provisional until the relevant primary record is produced.

Working transcription

The following is the repository's current working transcription, not a facsimile:

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Line 1  W R G O A B A B D
Line 2  M L I A O I
Line 3  W T B I M P A N E T P
Line 4  M L I A B O A I A Q C  [commonly reported as crossed out]
Line 5  I T T M T S A M S T G A B
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The supplied report instead uses M at the start of line 3, treats line 2 as deleted and reinterprets the terminal C on line 4 as an incomplete S. It does not explain why those variants were selected. Future analysis must preserve all plausible variants and state in advance which version is being tested.

Assessment of the technical-lettering hypothesis

What can be observed

Available reproductions show upright block capitals with broadly uniform stroke weight. That description is an observation. It is reasonable to ask whether technical work, schooling, military service or routine clerical practice influenced the style.

The supplied report moves directly from that general appearance to Webb's occupation. That is an authorship inference, and it needs comparison evidence. Many tradespeople and non-tradespeople were taught block capitals. A shared convention can reduce the individuality of writing rather than identify a writer.

Why occupation does not identify the writer

A defensible comparison would require:

- authenticated Webb handwriting from a similar period;
- enough natural writing to show variation within Webb's own hand;
- contemporaneous comparison writing from other plausible writers;
- a high-generation, documented image of the questioned inscription;
- declared criteria for inclusion, exclusion and uncertainty; and
- an examiner who records questioned features before learning the proposed identity and occupational theory.

None of that material appears in the supplied report. It therefore cannot support a conclusion about authorship.

The historical drawing-standard claim

The report cites an "ASA CB1" standard from 1934, revised in 1944. The National Library of Australia catalogues the relevant national works as Australian standard engineering drawing practice, numbers CZ.1-1941 and CZ1-1946. The report's identifier, title and dates were not reconciled with those records.

Even the correct standard would show only that a lettering convention existed. It would not show that Webb was trained under it, retained its letterforms, wrote the inscription or used a particular stroke order. The actual standards and Webb's training record must be examined before the hypothesis can move beyond background plausibility.

Assessment of individual-character claims

Letter G

The report says both G characters were started at the internal spur and written clockwise. It gives no annotated plate or junction analysis demonstrating that sequence. Stroke order may sometimes be inferred from overlap, interruption, pressure or deposition evidence, but a static low-generation reproduction does not automatically preserve those features. No stroke-order finding is accepted here.

Terminal C or incomplete S

The report claims that the terminal line-4 character matches the upper lobe of line-5 S characters to within 0.1 mm. It provides no image scale, coordinates, uncertainty, repeat measurements or source resolution. The precision is therefore unsupported.

The further claim that "phonological and morphological flow" supports S is misplaced. The underlying words are unknown, so their sound and structure cannot be examined. The character must remain a declared C/S variant until better source material supports discrimination.

Marks around O

The overmark may be a deletion, correction, separator, incidental contact or another notation. Calling it a proofreader's null sign or a laboratory-log convention without a matched reference alphabet is speculation. It should be recorded descriptively before an interpretation is assigned.

Telegraphic S

The supplied report cites "Clegg, 1939" for a top bar used to distinguish S from 8 or 5, but gives no title, publisher, page or bibliographic entry. The claim has been removed pending a traceable PMG training manual or other period source. It would still require evidence that Webb received or used that training.

Initialism, cipher and poetry

The sequence is short and transcription-dependent. That limits the power of frequency, periodicity and language tests. The supplied report says Australian Defence, the FBI and modern computational linguists ruled out relevant cipher models, but it does not identify the reports or reproduce the tests. It also cites "Abbott et al., 2019" in the text without including that work in its references.

A University of Adelaide project report from 2010 reached a more cautious result. Its text-type testing found no significant differences between the categories examined and said the significance of observed initialisms was undetermined. That does not prove a cipher, an initialism or any particular source text.

The supplied report's phrase "poetic acrostic" is also imprecise. If each letter represents the first letter of a word, the result would be an initial-letter mnemonic or initialism. An acrostic ordinarily uses selected letters from a completed text to form another message. More importantly, metre depends on words, syllables and stress. A string of initials cannot establish iambic tetrameter or pentameter without recovering the words.

At least four broad models remain live:

- 1 initials of remembered or drafted text;
- 2 a cipher or encoding scheme that cannot be resolved from the available length;
- 3 initials of places, movements or another personal list; and
- 4 notation whose intended meaning is now unrecoverable, including meaningless writing.

The present evidence does not rank unpublished poetry above those alternatives.

A reproducible way forward

- 1 Secure the source image. Identify the highest-generation surviving image, its holder, capture process, scale, alterations and chain of copies.
- 2 Freeze transcription variants. Have independent readers transcribe the image before being shown proposed solutions. Publish every disputed character and deletion rule.
- 3 Locate known Webb writing. Seek authenticated, approximately contemporaneous exemplars with enough material to characterise normal variation.
- 4 Separate observation from context. A competent document examiner should record features before receiving Webb's identity, occupation or the preferred explanation.
- 5 Test occupational references. Examine the actual CZ1 standards, relevant trade-school materials and PMG manuals. Compare their illustrated alphabets rather than relying on job titles.
- 6 Pre-register computational tests. State the transcription, corpus, null model, scoring rule and decision threshold before running the real sequence. Publish code and full output.
- 7 Use discriminating alternatives. Compare poetry, prose, personal mnemonics, place sequences and random controls. A positive result against a weak baseline is not evidence for one preferred story.

Conclusion

The original document sounds more certain than its evidence permits. Its strongest contribution is not a solved authorship or poetic interpretation, but a set of questions that can be tested: whether the lettering resembles period technical instruction, whether disputed characters can be resolved from better imagery, and whether an initial-letter model performs better than fair alternatives.

For now, the technically defensible conclusion is narrow. Webb may have had occupational experience relevant to block lettering. That fact does not identify his hand, recover the missing words or determine the purpose of the inscription.

Sources

- 1 State Records of South Australia. 'But what poison?' Mystery of the Somerton Man. [\[archives.sa.gov.au\]](https://archives.sa.gov.au)
- 2 Rebecca Opie, ABC News, 2 August 2022. The Somerton Man has been named. What do we know about Carl 'Charles' Webb? [\[abc.net.au\]](https://abc.net.au)
- 3 Eugene Boisvert, ABC News, 6 July 2026. SA Police report to coroner into Somerton Man case complete 'very soon'. [\[abc.net.au\]](https://abc.net.au)
- 4 National Archives of Australia. Series descriptions and examples for A433 and B2455. [\[naa.gov.au\]](https://naa.gov.au) [\[naa.gov.au\]](https://naa.gov.au)
- 5 National Library of Australia. Catalogue records for Australian standard engineering drawing practice, CZ.1-1941 and CZ1-1946. [\[catalogue.nla.gov.au\]](https://catalogue.nla.gov.au) [\[catalogue.nla.gov.au\]](https://catalogue.nla.gov.au)
- 6 University of Adelaide Somerton Man project archive. Final Report 2010 and primary-source index. [\[eleceng.adelaide.edu.au\]](https://eleceng.adelaide.edu.au) [\[eleceng.adelaide.edu.au\]](https://eleceng.adelaide.edu.au)
- 7 UK Forensic Science Regulator. Forensic science providers: validation and Forensic science activities: interpretation and communication. Used as present-day quality benchmarks, not as law governing an Australian historical document. [\[gov.uk\]](https://gov.uk) [\[gov.uk\]](https://gov.uk)